

# The Category Design Canvas

Stop competing in someone else's category. Name your own.



## 🧐 the problem 01

- What is wrong or painful about the situation as it stands?
- What is wrong with the status quo — and why has nobody fixed it?
- Can you name a new need that your skills let you solve, or a skill you have and find the need for it?

## 👤 your customers 02

- Who cares about this problem and is directly affected by it?
- Define the customer avatar as: a specific user (who) experiencing pain x (what) in scenario y (when), who wants to do z (how).

## 🌐 the landscape 03

- Are there direct or indirect competitors in this space?
- How do you differentiate from them?
- Is there a category already in place — and who named it?

## 📢 your point of view 04

- What do you believe about this problem that the incumbents don't?
- What is the old way, what is the new way, and what changed in the world to make the new way possible now?
- How do you want people to see your company in one sentence?

## 🗨️ frame the problem 05

- Describe the problem as if you were explaining it to a five-year-old.
- If they can repeat it back, you have a frame. If they can't, keep cutting.

## ✚ your solution 06

- How does your solution directly solve the problem as you framed it?
- What is your unique angle — the thing about the solution only you would build?

## 💬 name the category 07

- The category name should describe the nature of the problem, not your product.
- Make it snappy, short, descriptive and unique. Facebook coined “social network”; Uber coined “on-demand transportation”.
- Say it out loud. Would a journalist use it in a headline?

## ★ your unfair advantage 08

- What do you have that nobody else can copy quickly — a dataset, a distribution partner, a method, a licence, a decade of domain knowledge?
- Why you, why now?
- What would a well-funded competitor still lack after twelve months of trying?

## 📦 the business model 09

- Explain how the offering makes money using a familiar comparison, so people can picture it instantly. Example: “the Lululemon of scrubs” (Figs).
- Who pays, how often, and what do they get each time they pay?

## ♥ the category lead 10

- Who is seen as the leader of this category today — or of the nearest existing category?
- What would it take for customers, press and investors to see you as the leader instead: proof, language, distribution, or a public point of view?
- What is the first move that makes the category exist in other people's minds?